

To counter the quality problems in low-light shoots, most camcorders now have inbuilt lights that, when set on Auto mode, will automatically switch on when the lux level is low. Higher-end camcorders may not have an inbuilt light, but will have a “shoe”. This is a slot to connect optional accessories such as microphones or lights. The shoe is linked to the camcorder’s controls, enabling it to seamlessly control the attached accessory. Newer camcorders are beginning to appear with LED flashlights rather than the traditional incandescent type. While this might push up the cost of a bit, the investment is good, as LED lights consume less electricity (read: do not drain the batteries as fast), and have a longer life than the incandescent variety.

Additionally, if you plan to use the camcorder to take still photos (not recommended; see §1.2.4 (Still Photos)) you will also need to factor in the requirement for a pop-up flashlight. Like in digital cameras, the flashlight will pop up when light levels are below optimum and you are shooting still pictures.

Higher-end camcorders also have a total darkness shooting option. Primarily, this uses infrared technology to shoot in the dark. Picture quality has much left to be desired, though you will be able to get passable results for some shots such as slow-moving night-time animals or a sleeping baby.

One other method to improve the brightness of the picture is to use video signal gain, which is optionally available in some camcorders. Gain is the technical term for increasing the amplitude or strength of a signal. However, be warned that gain adjustments can decrease picture quality and increase the noise in the video. So you will need to experiment with the various gain settings, measured in decibels (0 dB, 6 dB, 18 dB, etc.), before determining what works best for the given situation.

1.2.3. Zoom—Optical Vs. Digital

For all practical purposes, ignore the digital zoom number given by the manufacturer. This is pure marketing hype. Digital zoom relies